



FUNDRAISING



Food delivery service
Calo scores \$39M in
Series B extension as it
sets eyes on the UK



Middle Eastern food delivery startup Calo said Tuesday it has raised \$39 million in a Series B extension that was led by Aljazira Capital. The fundraise, which was more than 1.5x of its original [\\$25 million raise in December](#), also saw participation from existing backers such as Nuwa Capital, STV, Khwarizmi Ventures, and Al Faisaliah Group.

The company is using this funding to expand into territories like the U.K. and to explore different partnerships in physical space.

Calo primarily offers ready-to-eat meals that customers can heat up later. The company delivers different plans to cater to various health goals. The company's founder, Ahmed Al Rawi, told TechCrunch the startup's revenue grew by "close to 100%." Calo delivered more than 10 million meals last year in Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Kuwait, Qatar, and Bahrain. While Al Rawi didn't provide a number for this year, he said the deliveries were growing in step with revenue.

Those numbers, along with its brand, technology, and operational excellence, convinced Aljazira Capital to invest in the Saudi company. "Calo represents a compelling opportunity at the intersection of healthtech, foodtech, and consumer subscription models," Rawan AlRasheed, director of venture capital at Aljazira Capital, told TechCrunch in a statement.

IMAGE CREDITS: CALO

DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

[Book Your Table >](#)

Most Popular



- Key sections of the US Constitution deleted from government's website
- Three weeks after acquiring Windsurf, Cognition offers staff the exit door
- Roku launches Howdy, a \$2.99 ad-free streaming service
- Spotify raises subscription prices
- The uproar over Vogue's AI-generated ad isn't just about fashion

The startup is also making moves to expand in the U.K., where last year it acquired two meal delivery services, [Fresh Fitness Food](#) and [Detox Kitchen](#). While Fresh Fitness Food didn't raise any money, Detox Kitchen had raised just over \$3.4 million via a mix of venture-backed and equity crowdfunding rounds, according to Crunchbase data.

"We spoke to over 50 meal subscription businesses worldwide, ranging from the U.S. to Asia, in 2023-24 to learn about what is an exciting market for us to expand to. We realized the UK was the right market for us to expand. We thought that both companies that we acquired had a great culture fit to work with Calo," Al Rawi told TechCrunch over a call.

He added that Calo acquired these businesses because they had their operational layer figured out, and the startup just wanted to upscale the tech and branding layer.

- Lina Khan points to Figma IPO as vindication of M&A scrutiny
- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

[REGISTER NOW](#)

Al Rawi said Calo spent most of this year integrating its technology and process with both U.K. platforms without laying off any of the existing personnel. The startup finished the integration work in July and has been slowly making a marketing push in the U.K.

Calo can currently deliver meals in London daily and in other parts of the U.K. two to three times a week. The founder said that Calo is targeting to get to 10x its revenue in the U.K. in the next three years.

Those U.K. ambitions will be met with competition. Apart from traditional food delivery giants like Just Eat and Deliveroo, Calo will also compete with meal-box services such as [Gousto](#) and [Wicked Kitchen](#).

While Calo is focused on growing in the U.K., the company is also looking to acquire different meal-kit services around the world. The company is expanding physical locations, too, including retail stores and kiosks in other regions. In addition, Calo has partnered with a gym chain called Armah Sports Company in Saudi Arabia to offer a bundle of Calo and gym subscriptions.

Topics: [food delivery](#) [Fundraising](#) [gcc](#) [meal kits](#)

[Nuwa Capital](#)



Ivan Mehta

Ivan covers global consumer tech developments at TechCrunch. He is based out of India and has previously...

[View Bio](#) >



IMAGE CREDITS: CALO

FUNDRAISING



Calo raises \$25 million to expand its ready-to-eat meal service beyond the Middle East

Ivan Mehta — 2:30 AM PST · December 30, 2024

A business built around increasingly customized ready-to-eat meals has netted Middle Eastern startup [Calo](#) a sizeable funding injection as it looks to expand both *what* it can offer its time-strapped customers and *where* it delivers its growing range of just-heat-to-eat dishes.

The meal delivery market in the Middle East will hit \$11.2 billion by 2030, according to a report from [MarkNtel Advisors published last year](#). Food aggregators such as Careem, Deliveroo, and Talabat have built big businesses by banking on the

Advertisement

habits of busy professionals ordering food in rather than making meals themselves — fueled in large part [by the COVID-19 pandemic](#).

Riyadh-based Calo differentiates itself by offering customized meal subscriptions for specialized segments like weight loss, high protein intake, or balanced meals — targeting customers who care what they are eating, not merely when their food will arrive.

The startup plans to further lean into meal customization to cater to more personalized segments and food needs, such as meals geared toward those seeking muscle gain, or suffering from diabetes, IBS (irritable bowel syndrome), or PCOS (polycystic ovary syndrome). Calo's premise is that people who fall into these categories will pay a premium for food customization features that meet their convenience needs.

The company is so confident it's onto something that it's also in the process of acquiring an unnamed food startup in the U.K. to expand its footprint outside the Middle East next year — with ambitions to go global.

To fund the new growth vectors, Calo has raised \$25 million in Series B funding led by Nuwa Capital with participation from Khwarizmi Ventures and STV. Notably, all these investors are returning investors.

Calo is now valued at around \$250 million, according to multiple sources TechCrunch spoke to.

Newsletters

[See More ↗](#)

Subscribe for the industry's biggest tech news

TechCrunch Daily News



Every weekday and Sunday, you can get the best of TechCrunch's coverage.

Startups Weekly



Startups are the core of TechCrunch, so get our best coverage delivered weekly.

TechCrunch Week in Review



Get the best of our coverage, delivered to your inbox every Saturday.

TechCrunch Mobility



TechCrunch Mobility is your destination for transportation news and insight.

No newsletters selected.

Subscribe

By submitting your email, you agree to our [Terms](#) and [Privacy Notice](#).



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy

hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

The startup, which operates in Saudi Arabia, UAE, Kuwait, Qatar, and Bahrain, allows users to pick healthier ready meals, including breakfast, lunch, dinner, and a snack — offering meal filters such as balanced, high protein, low carb, and vegetarian. Users can customize their meals and plans and even skip days.

The approach has built momentum in the region: This year Calo says it has served 10 million meals, with the average cost of a meal ranging from \$7 to \$9.

Beyond the Series B round, Calo said it's aiming to close a \$25 million extension round by Q1 2025 and has a goal of going public in the next few years. So this might be its last funding tranche before the company lists in Saudi Arabia. (With the Series B closed, Calo has raised a total of \$51 million across multiple rounds.)

"It is a powerful idea to deliver ready-to-eat meals that are nutritious, healthy, and customized to your needs," Khaled Talhouni, managing partner at Nuwa Capital, told TechCrunch over a call.

"Whether you want to build muscle or lose weight,

Calo helps you personalize meals, and that idea has us excited.”

“The GCC (Gulf Cooperation Council) market has an inbuilt propensity to order food. That’s why companies like Talabat and Deliveroo are successful. Plus, Calo’s logistic model, which is like a bulk milk run, puts them in an advantageous position,” he added.

Calo was started in Bahrain by Ahmed Al Rawi in 2019. Prior to that, Al Rawi built another startup for people to book sports venues and join ongoing games. Later, he advised startups in New York before starting Calo.

“Before building the startup, I thought there wasn’t much to be done in food delivery as startups like Careem already existed. But I realized that a segment of customers wanted customized meals with specific calorie counts or ingredients, and incumbents didn’t offer this level of personalization.” Al Rawi told TechCrunch over a

Latest Security
Startups AI
Venture Apps
Apple



Events
Podcasts
Newsletters



CALO FOUNDER AHMED AL RAWI

IMAGE CREDITS:CALO

He noted that services existed to give meal recommendations based on a person's height, weight, age, gender, and activity, but they didn't provide actual meals, which wasn't ideal for busy professionals — hence Al Rawi spotting an opportunity for more customized meal delivery.

According to Calo, people are buying 30% more meals on its service versus an on-demand food aggregator (i.e. such as Careem). It credits this stickiness to combining meal delivery convenience with saving its customers the hassle of finding the right dish to meet their health goals.

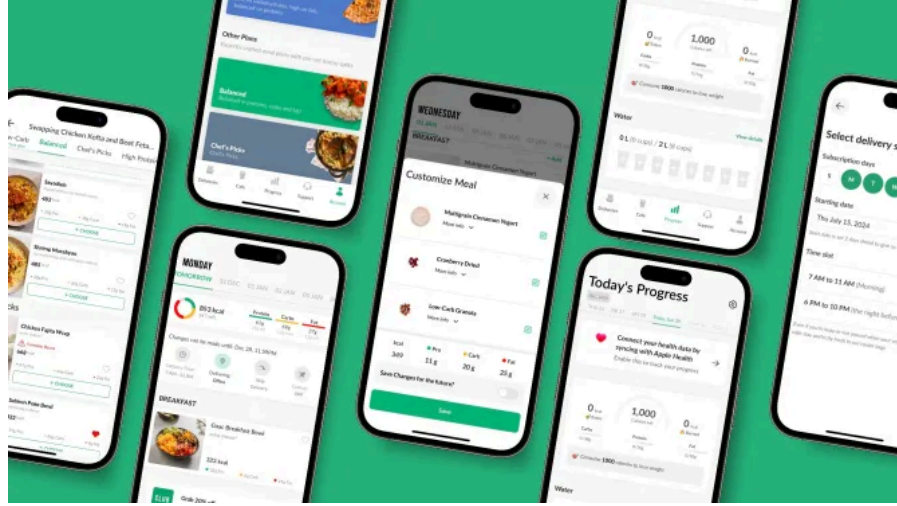


IMAGE CREDITS: CALO

The company operates one central kitchen per city, using vans to make deliveries across cities with help from smaller vans and individual riders. Per Al Rawi, Calo currently has 200 vans driving across the Middle East.

Customers receive their meals in a chilled state, which they can reheat in a microwave or by using a pan on their hob. The startup said it has been able to keep its ops quick and lean by not having a lot of delivery centers and by sticking to scheduled deliveries.

Future Roadmap

In addition to opening up the new segments mentioned above, Calo plans to introduce even deeper personalization for users — where they will, for example, be able to specify the exact portion of protein, carbs, or fat they want in a meal, or remove an ingredient.

The startup is also experimenting with new business models, such as retail kiosks for grab-and-go meals in places like corporate offices, and an on-demand delivery service.



IMAGE CREDITS: CALO

Currently, Saudi Arabia represents 70% of Calo's revenues, with UAE coming second at 15%. However, Al Rawi told us it expects the UAE to grow exponentially in the coming years.

This year Calo hit nine figures in annualized revenue and runs at a nearly break-even state. The company aims to reach profitability by next year, ahead of going public.

"Because we are capital-efficient, we didn't need to raise money and would have grown organically. But we saw new growth opportunities. So we primarily raised money to expand our business models, cater to more segments, and also open up new geographies that we serve in," Al Rawi added.

Topics: [calo](#) [Exclusive](#) [food delivery](#) [Fundraising](#)

[meal delivery](#) [Middle East](#) [Nuwa Capital](#)

[Saudi Arabia](#) [Startups](#) [United Kingdom](#)





Ivan Mehta

X in

Ivan covers global consumer tech developments at TechCrunch. He is based out of India and has previously...

View Bio >

KEEP READING



Thistle launches meal kits to make nutritious baby food at home

Lora Kolodny — 11:12 AM PST · February 23, 2017

Food delivery startup [Thistle](#) was never in the business of making meal kits, those boxes of pre-measured ingredients and recipes to help customers cook at home. The startup's married cofounders, Ashwin Cheriyan and Shiri Avnery, thought that prepared meals, ready-to-heat or raw and ready-to-eat, were a better fit for their busy customers. Meal kits, they said, felt like time consuming and frustrating cooking lessons when they tried them personally.

But the startup has made an exception and is launching Thistle Baby meal kits for busy parents who want to make nutritious foods for their babies and toddlers at home. Avnery said, "When I became a mom, I would buy things at the grocery and feel like they were not up to my quality standards all the time. Even a lot of the healthier options are over-processed, pureed, with a watery consistency. They also don't taste like real fruits or veggies. And you're left wondering how long this has been on the shelf and in what kind of conditions."



THISTLE BABY SENDS RECIPES AND POUCHES OF ORGANIC INGREDIENTS TO PARENTS TO MAKE BABY FOOD AT HOME.

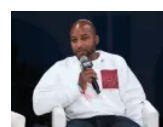
Thistle Baby was designed to give parents the health and taste benefits of homemade, organic and gluten-free baby food, as well as the feeling of pride that comes from making meals for their little ones. Cheriyan said, "We think this takes 80% of the hassle out of making the food at home. And



Latest in Startups

[See More](#)

FUNDRAISING



How to actually raise a seed round: Actionable advice from top investors at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events

- 13 hours ago

STARTUPS



Figma's IPO success is 'a little bit of a meme stock,' says Sapphire Ventures' Jai Das

Rebecca Bellan,
Theresa Loconsolo

- 15 hours ago

because you steam, puree and add spices on your own, you start to really learn your baby's preferences, while instilling healthy eating habits as early as possible." Thistle specializes in plant-based ingredients. Its service has always been vegan and vegetarian-friendly, though they offer omnivore meals, too.

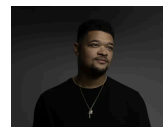
The Thistle Baby meal kit consists of vacuum-sealed bags of apportioned, organic ingredients, flash-frozen to preserve flavor. A parent would open up the pouch, and steam and puree it however they like, then add spices also provided in the meal kit at levels they or their kids like best. The company says its prices work out to \$2 per toddler or infant meal. Before now, the startup was trialing its Thistle Baby service with an invitation-only group of subscribers. As of next week, Thistle Baby will become available to any customers who sign up for it.



THISTLE CO-FOUNDERS ASHWIN CHERIYAN AND SHIRI AVNERY WITH THEIR CHILD.

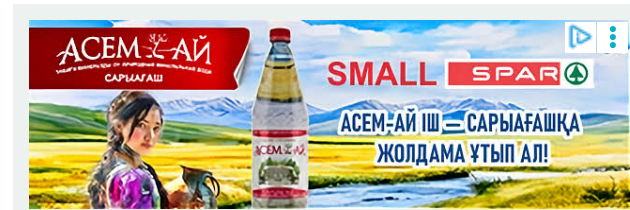
The startup sees its main competition as baby foods sold in boxes, pouches, and jars by groceries. However, a few other e-commerce food businesses deliver kid-friendly meals or meal kits to families' doors, too. For example, [Lily & Bella](#) in Dallas delivers organic ingredients and recipes to make baby food at home; Los Angeles-based [Caer](#) offers low-sugar organic, prepared baby foods for delivery; and [NurtureLife](#) in Chicago offers ready-

STARTUPS



Payment platform Lava raises \$5.8M to build digital wallets for the 'agent-native economy'

Dominic-Madori Davis
- 16 hours ago



to-eat meals tailored to kids’ developmental stage and food preferences.

According to a recent [Nielsen survey](#), globally 14% of consumers are already buying groceries and household goods online and via mobile. A full 30% of customers said they would be willing to do so. It remains to be seen what portion of the massive baby foods and formula market may shift to e-commerce models like Thistle’s. Nielsen estimates that market generates over \$30 billion in annual sales today.

Topics: [baby food](#) [Biotech & Health](#) [Climate](#)

[e-commerce](#) [e-grocery](#) [food delivery](#)

[foodtech](#) [meal kits](#) [Media & Entertainment](#)

[organic baby food](#) [startup](#) [Startups](#) [thistle](#)

[Thistle.co](#)



[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [t](#) [✉](#) [🔗](#)

Lora Kolodny

Emerging Tech Editor, Video Host | [X](#)

Lora Kolodny was emerging technologies editor and video host at TechCrunch.

[View Bio](#) >

Loading the next article





[TechCrunch Staff](#)

[Contact Us](#)

[Advertise](#)

[Crunchboard Jobs](#)

[Site Map](#)

[Terms of Service](#)

[Privacy Policy](#)

[RSS Terms of Use](#)

[OpenAI](#)

[Perplexity](#)

[Cisco](#)

[DeepMind](#)

[Windsurf](#)

[Tech Layoffs](#)

[ChatGPT](#)